

WEEKENDER
INSIDE
TODAY

THE AGE

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Big housing shake-up

State plans to abolish commission

By PHILIP CHUBB, State political reporter

The Victorian Government will abolish the Housing Commission. It will be replaced by a permanent head of the Ministry of Housing who will be solely and directly responsible to the Minister.

Federal bank lending \$900m shy

From RUSSELL BARTON and MICHELLE GRATTAN

CANBERRA — The Federal Government's own Commonwealth Savings Bank is lending about \$900 million less for housing than it could under the Government's rules.

While the Commonwealth is the largest single lender to home buyers it has the lowest ratio of loans to deposits of all the saving banks.

Figures published in the Commonwealth Gazette show that at the end of December the Commonwealth's home loans represented 48.9 per cent of its deposits. Under the Government's regulations, all banks must have at least 50 per cent of their deposits.

Cabinet yesterday afternoon had another long talk about housing. Sources said later that further work was being done on three initiatives.

Pressure on banks to lend more money for housing. A taxation reform to reduce the interest burden on home buyers hardest hit by high rates. A re-examination of the Home Savings Grants scheme to increase the maximum grant and to help the present nine-month waiting period.

The Government is thinking of a clutch of measures rather than just one option. Government sources say that the Prime Minister, Mr Fraser, was pushing for quick decisions on housing, would like to make an announcement in Parliament next week. However, it is not certain whether the Cabinet will be able to meet this deadline.

Asked yesterday whether the Government would announce its decisions before the Victorian election, Mr Fraser said: "Well it could, but it will be when we're ready."

Mr Fraser said that his Government would decide its housing plan "relatively shortly" and that it would complement the proposals announced by Victoria's Premier Mr Thompson, in its election policy speech.

Realistic

Mr Fraser said on ABC radio's "Midday with Schillinger" that he was delighted that Mr Thompson was "the first Premier to really say on the housing problem, in a realistic and sensible way."

The Victorian announcement, although discussed by Mr Fraser and Mr Thompson at length at the weekend, has complicated the Federal Government's problems, because Federal measures must dovetail with those of the State.

Sources said that several options had been discussed to encourage deposits.

One problem worrying the Government is lending on the basis to lend more for houses in that this could squeeze money for local government and business.

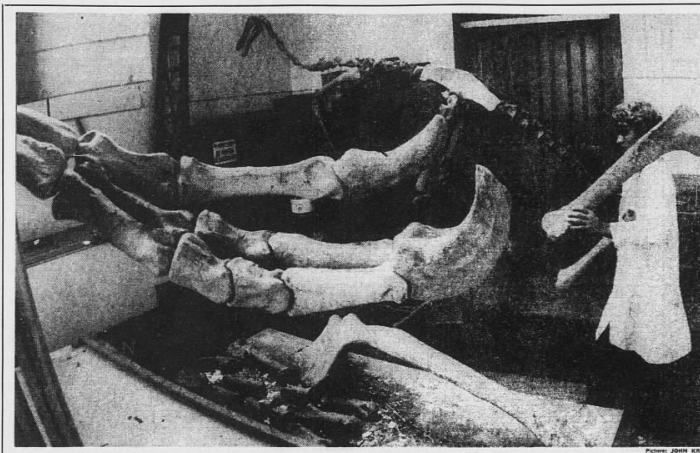
The Commonwealth bank's home lending ratio of 48.9 per cent in December compared with 50.7 per cent for the ANZ bank and 51.1 per cent for the Bank of New South Wales. Only the National Bank with a 49.9 per cent ratio is near the Commonwealth's.

At present, Commonwealth holds total deposits of more than \$3500 million, about 1 per cent of the total on the home lending ceiling represents about 180 million less in housing loans.

United States' Colonial Bank is now engaged in the search for increased housing money, it would seem logical that his bank could be encouraged to boost its.

But it is not as simple as that. The Commonwealth's mortgage and Commonwealth Finance Functions. Twenty seven per cent of its deposits are held in its own, churches, charities, and directed into the Commonwealth Government bodies (for which it receives a return for which it receives more than the 12.5 per cent on housing loans to charge on housing loans).

PAGE 2 Surplus lend key to Liberal home plan.



Kevin Kelly picks his way through prehistoric remains which will go on display with two Chinese dinosaur skeletons in October.

Introducing, from China, the duck-billed dinosaur

By KAREN COOKE

Taxidermists at the National Museum will soon take time out from stuffing orang-utans, bats and jaguars to recreate two Chinese dinosaurs.

The dinosaur, will be on loan from the Institute of Palaeontology and Palaeontological in Peking. The National Museum's chief preparator, Mr Michael Frayser, says it will take at least

a year for his team of four to make moulds to cast polyurethane bones.

One dinosaur is a duckbilled creature which lived in water about 70 million years ago. It is a seven-metre long sauropodomorph.

The other is a manomichirodon, 22 metres long, which prefers to plod Sichuan Province about 150 million years ago.

Both have been stirring in a fossil exhibition in Japan that attracted 50,000 visitors a day. The two are now packed in 35 crates on a ship bound for Melbourne, and will arrive later this month.

In October, they will go on show as the centrepiece of the Chinese Dinosaur Exhibition at the Museum. The mounting work, which will be in full swing by then, will also be on display, as well as dinosaur remains found recently in Victoria's Ovens Range. Visitors will be able to handle two high bones.

The team will make two replicas of each dinosaur. One set for the museum, and one will be sent back to China with the originals in about 15 months.

Of the conservatively estimated 100,000 that the project will need, the University Foundation has given \$20,000 for the work on the replicas that are to stay in Australia. Friends of the National Museum of Victoria have given \$5000 from the Potter Foundation, and the River Charitable Trust has given \$2000, for the transport of the dinosaurs to the museum.

Mr Frayser says his team is "just about ready to go" with the project. He estimates it will use 400 litres of silicon rubber (at \$18 a litre) to make the flexible moulds.

Mr Frayser recently created a life-size whale which is now in the museum's foyer. To get it there from the operators' workshop, it had to be lowered by ropes down the outside wall of the building.

Record number jobless

From IAN DAVIS

CANBERRA — Unemployment reached record levels in Australia last month and the Federal Government warned yesterday that it was unlikely to improve during the next few months.

Figures released by the Bureau of Statistics yesterday showed that 402,000 people were out of work in February. This was a rise of 41,000 from January and the largest number of unemployed since the present series of statistics began in 1976.

According to some statistics, it is the largest number of unemployed since the war.

Victoria recorded a big rise — 14,000 in its total number of unemployed in February. The State moved against the national trend by recording falls.

But Victoria continues to have the lowest unemployment rate, 6.6 per cent, compared with the national unemployment rate of 7.7 per cent.

Nationally, the main increase in unemployment occurred among workers over 20 years of age. Unemployment among this group rose by 37,000 in February to 260,400.

Unemployment among school leavers fell from 72,000 to 68,300. Unemployment among women rose from 17,000 to 18,200.

Unemployment among men rose from 24,000 to 25,000. Women seeking part-time work represented 17,000 of the increase.

There was a rise of 27,000 in the number of people seeking full-time work and an increase of 13,000 in the number seeking part-time work.

The Treasurer, Mr Howard, described the figures as "high and disappointing". He stuck by his Budget prediction that there

would be a slight rise in unemployment through 1981-82.

The acting Minister for Employment and Youth Affairs, Mr Moore, said: "The significant increase, agreed over recent months, the level of industrial production and the large number of hefty wage claims currently in prospect have obviously influenced the ability and willingness of employers to maintain and expand employment opportunities."

The president of the ACTU, Mr Dolan, said he was dismayed at the increase which was just a further indication of the mismanagement of the whole of the economy by this Government.

Labour's spokesman on employment, Mr Hawke, said: "The Federal Government must shoulder a large part of the responsibility for this tragic mess."

PAGE 16 Liberals, Labor disagree on jobs figure

Reprimand for Card

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PAGE 16 Liberals, Labor disagree on jobs figure

Anthony denies Nugan link

From IAN DAVIS

CANBERRA — The Deputy Prime Minister, Mr Anthony, yesterday denied the allegations that he was involved in the Channel Nine network that had collected on the failed Nugan Hand merchant bank, the leader of the Opposition.

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involved with organized crime and the drug industry.

Mr Anthony told Parliament that the allegations were "nothing but speculative matters by the Opposition".

In Sydney last night the Channel Nine reporter who interviewed Mr Anthony, Mr Patrick Lindsay, said the network had no involvement in the failed Nugan Hand merchant bank, the leader of the Opposition.

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He said: "It was to be a benign inquiry where information was gathered, but nothing acted on."

Mr Volkmann said the Minister who stopped the follow-through had no responsibility for the inquiry.

Mr Hayden told Parliament that as well as Mr Volkmann's affidavit naming Mr Anthony, he had heard from another journalistic source that Mr Anthony was the Minister referred to.

Mr Anthony, in a personal explanation to Parliament, said: "I have no knowledge of what is going on and have had no involvement with Nugan Hand."

The matter was raised three times in Parliament yesterday. After lunch, Mr Hayden twice tried to start a debate expressing concern at Mr Volkmann's claims about Mr Anthony's involvement in the inquiry.

Mr Frayser, to answer them, the Leader of the House, Mr Sinclair, asked him twice.

Continued: PAGE 3

Secretary of State, Mr Haig, to President Jimmy Carter. Mr Haig, in a letter to Mr Carter, expressed the "Post" story was in keeping with a long-standing policy not to report to reporting to the United States.

Moreover, a report in today's "New York Times" expresses the "Post" may not have got it quite right. The "Times" story, which said the "Post" was "in keeping with a long-standing policy not to report to reporting to the United States."

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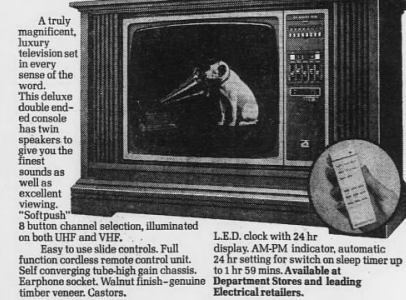
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Saturday Extra

THAT MAN WHITE

Leonard Rodic talks to the Nobel Prize winner

LETTERS FROM THE PROFESSOR

The writings of Julius Gromer Miller

THE AGE

Saturday's Age now comes in two sections. Part 1 has all the news and sport.

Part 2 is Saturday Extra, the paper's new, expanded magazine section. If you buy Saturday's Age as a newspaper, remember to pick up both parts. With some deals, both parts come together.

NEWS SUMMARY

Howard admits hefty deficit

The Federal Treasurer, Mr Howard, acknowledges that Australia will run a hefty balance of payments deficit this financial year. He abandons his Budget forecast that the current account deficit will be more than covered by capital inflow, saying it is perfectly obvious there has been a change in the expectations on the external account over the past few months.

Test-tube inquiry

The State Government announces an inquiry into the social and cultural implications of the test-tube baby programme.

Gallagher silent

Mr Norm Gallagher, Federal secretary of the Builders' Labourers Federation, declines to say whether he will obey a Supreme Court order.

Passport security

The Royal Commission on drug trafficking is told that passport control at Australian airports has all the elements of a Marx Brothers movie.

US warned

The State Government warns Nicaragua's revolutionary Government that it must provide more violence in Central America, Nicaraguan leaders warn.

SPOT SPOT

The Archbishop of Canterbury, Dr Robert Runcie, has revealed that the serious during last year's Royal wedding was caused by the release in Thailand of a commercial for padded bras was about the same as his wedding with the common refrain in the ceremony just as he was saying "Thanks be to God".

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WEATHER TODAY

CITY: Fine, Sunny. Expected

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